



Punch perfect: Reinier de Ridder (right) won in commanding fashion against Robert Whittaker (left). GETTY IMAGES

THE KNIGHT SHIFT

Reinier de Ridder's latest victory has **thrust his name** into the middleweight title conversation.

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Reinier de Ridder cemented his status as a formidable force in the Ultimate Fighting Championship (UFC) middleweight division with a hard-fought split decision victory over former champion Robert Whittaker at UFC Fight Night in Abu Dhabi. In a gruelling contest that showcased both fighters' resilience, de Ridder outlasted Whittaker, landing significantly more total strikes (192 compared to 70) and securing two crucial takedowns.

Despite being dropped by an overhand right in the third round, 'The Dutch Knight' demonstrated remarkable recovery, weathering the storm and re-establishing control — ultimately swaying two judges to score the bout 48-47 in his favour.

This triumph marks de Ridder's fourth consecutive win in the UFC,

taking his record to an impressive 4-0 since signing with the promotion in September 2024.

Prior to his UFC tenure, de Ridder had already etched his name in combat sports history as a dominant two-division champion in ONE Championship, simultaneously holding both the middleweight and light heavyweight titles.

His rapid ascent in the UFC includes submission victories over Gerald Meerschaert and Kevin Holland, as well as a TKO win against the highly rated Bo Nickal, highlighting his diverse skill set.